

database solution to move to an open source alternative, you have PostgreSQL, MySQL, NoSQL and MariaDB among various other options.

Chandigarh-based Jugnoo, which is among the early open source-adopting startups, recently moved from Tally and SAP ERP to open-sourced Odoo for its HR developments. Co-founder and CTO Chinmay Agarwal now plans to shift the company's other business processes also to open source.

"We liked the implementation of Odoo for HR, and it will be easy for us to transition ultimately to Odoo for other business processes too," Agarwal highlighted.

Cost saving

The prime benefit of switching to open source is cost saving. Online travel company MakeMyTrip that handles its online presence with a monthly traffic of over 22 million visits considers open source as an efficient alternative.

"At an optimal operating expenditure, we were able to exercise greater flexibility using open source components on our website," said Vikram Mehta, senior manager for information security, MakeMyTrip.

Airtel also counts on the efficiency and flexibility of open source. "Preferring open source lets us take control in order to make our decisions smoothly," Kumar said.

Kumar considers spending on open source technologies virtually puts zero burden. "If we have to take a licensed product, then its cost gets multiplied. You can compare this with any popular commercial solution and get the total saving. It will be in tunes of crores (tens of millions)," he pronounced.

Scalable till infinity

If you want to grow the presence of your company, scalability is the first

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parameter to consider. But this is something that you cannot achieve entirely with a proprietary solution. You must move to open source.

"Open source technology gives you the freedom to try, test and scale your solution, one step at a time," said Amit Ranjan, who co-founded SlideShare and is presently working at National e-Governance Division (NeGD).

NeGD has developed citizen-first projects including DigiLocker and Government e-Market (GeM) using open source technologies. This helps the government department to effectively offer its solutions to the public and enable scalability with ease. To date, DigiLocker has provided access to over a billion documents online. All that came from a small in-house team of around 14 people from diverse domains.

"Our small team is capable of doing tasks that require hundreds of engineers. It is all because of the skills that come from the open source support," Ranjan states.

External R&D

Among the lifelines of open source, community support comes at the top. "If a project has an active community, it will be regularly patched and improved," said Bob Canaway, CMO, BlackDuck.

In a recent interview with the IBM team, Linux Foundation CRO Mike Woster went a step further to describe community-supported open source software as an external R&D for organisations. "It is vastly vastly more advantageous

for organisations to consume, participate in and leverage the external R&D that is open source software," said Woster, who helped build the non-profit organisation become a \$65 million entity.

Enterprise-level security

Despite being low-cost, open source is a secure solution for your operations. "Open source enables us to be more lean, agile and secure and, hence, move faster in the competitive world," said Kumar of Airtel.

The team at MakeMyTrip has even embraced open source to secure its user experience.

"We leverage various open source deployments to manage security. These have greatly helped to enhance our security posture in the market," revealed Mehta of MakeMyTrip.

Digital transformation

Diverse companies, starting from Wal-Mart and Salesforce to General Electric and Philips, have begun adopting open source to digitise their services for end consumers. Analysts thus consider open source as a driver for digital transformation.

"The use of open source software and solutions is required in the model for digital transformation. CIOs and other leaders readily embracing open source will find that they are better positioned to transform their businesses," said Sanjay Gupta, adjunct research advisor, IDC.

"The ability to harness the collective power of individuals, partners and global development communities provides a transformative lever that is difficult to match. Open source-based platforms provide this ability in today's digital world," the analyst remarks. **EFY**

—Jagmeet Singh, a key member of Open Source For You and opensourceforu.com team